SSI PROGRAM

Best Practices Guidance with Action Item Recommendations

SSI Phase III: Site Advancement to Market

Indiana Strategic Sites Inventory (SSI) Program. Clean edition, November 2026. First drafted for the Indiana Economic Development Corporation in March 2024 (Draft V1); this edition corrects the draft and reconciles its figures to the program record. Content and recommendations are unchanged.



PREPARED FOR

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EDITION

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SSI PROGRAM

SSI Phase III: Site Advancement to Market

The Indiana SSI Program and the purpose of Phase III

The Indiana Strategic Sites Inventory (SSI) Program drives identification of industrial and commercial greenfield sites with competitive advantages for economic development projects. This includes a comprehensive process for site discovery and quality screening, preliminary engineering and environmental due diligence, landowner engagement, and site marketing resource production. The SSI Program is managed in dedicated phases to ensure development readiness and to protect against expenditure of resources on marginally competitive sites.

The Indiana SSI Program was initiated in 2018 with a funding grant from Duke Energy made to the Indiana Economic Development Corporation (IEDC). The program has grown in scope and scale with funding from Duke Energy, IEDC, NIPSCO, Wabash Valley Power Alliance, Hoosier Energy, and local contributions.

SSI Phase I: Site Discovery has been conducted for all 92 Indiana counties to identify and screen potential new high-quality megasite, technology megasite, heavy industrial, light industrial, agribusiness, and utility-scale solar greenfield sites. Phase I has produced 1,811 sites ranging in size from 25 to 5,200 acres with an average site size of 194 acres.

Indiana's local economic development organizations (LEDOs) participate in SSI Phase I Local Site Review Workshops. These workshops vet potential sites for strategic inventory pursuit through input from municipal and county officials. Sites not eliminated from consideration are ranked for relative value as a community economic development real estate asset on a 1.0 to 5.0 scale (1.0 = low priority, 5.0 = high priority). Sites ranked 4.0 or higher are prioritized for strategic site inventory pursuit.

Provided herein are recommendations for each LEDO to consider to ensure successful SSI Phase I site advancement to the open real estate market. Recommendations are presented in accordance with the four primary site advancement action items.

> **About this edition.** Draft V1 (March 2024) presented Action Item 1, Candidate Site Nomination, with six detailed recommendations, and Action Item 2, Landowner Engagement, in summary. Action Items 3 and 4 were outlined but not detailed before the program paused in 2025. This edition preserves that scope and corrects the draft's text and figures; the detailed recommendations for Action Items 2 through 4 are delivered with a funded Phase III engagement.

PURPOSE

EDO best practices guidance for effective SSI Phase I site advancement to the open real estate market. Position the site for development through zoning alignment. Prescribe the steps necessary to publish sites in Indiana's sites and buildings database with the minimum required documentation to support the competitive claims of the subject site.

OBJECTIVES

Provide each EDO with a clear set of site advancement action items in a logical workflow with defined outcomes. Assist EDOs with nomination of sites for advancement to market with the highest and best value to community economic development. Encourage collection of site information that exceeds minimum sites and buildings database publishing requirements to create a compelling site marketing package.

FOUR ACTION ITEMS

- Candidate Site Nomination
- Landowner Engagement
- Development Positioning
- Site Programming

Each site advancement action item, with its recommendations, is presented in this document. Each recommendation states the action, its intended outcome, the rationale, and the potential impediments to consider in execution.

Candidate Site Nomination

Candidate Site Nomination is the first site advancement action item toward graduating an SSI Program site to the open real estate market in a development-ready capacity. Care is taken here to select sites with the best project attraction value for the host community. The goal is to advance sites to market that:

1. are development-ready based on transportation and utility infrastructure access and capacity, and on local entitlement factors;
2. align with viable industry targets;
3. do not compete with existing competitive industrial and commercial sites of verifiable quality; and
4. have a high likelihood of surviving formal due diligence.

There are six implementation recommendations for the Candidate Site Nomination action item. Each is presented on the pages that follow with its action, intended outcome, rationale, and potential impediments.

PURPOSE

EDO guidance for effective SSI Phase I site advancement to the open real estate market. Prescribe the steps necessary to publish sites in Indiana's sites and buildings database with the minimum required documentation to support the competitive claims of the subject site.

RECOMMENDATIONS SUMMARY

1. Review SSI Sites Ranked 4+
2. Confirm Infrastructure
3. Complete SSI Phase I Site Readiness Questionnaire
4. Apply Industry Targets
5. Review Existing Sites
6. Nominate SSI Sites for Advancement

ACTION ITEM

Candidate Site Nomination

1ST

SSI site graduation to market begins with candidate site nomination. As the first site advancement action item, care is taken here to select a site with the best project attraction value for the host community.

> ***PRO TIP***
>
> *While SSI Phase I may have produced multiple quality sites ranked 4 or higher, it is imperative that there is a high degree of confidence that a candidate site will serve community industry targets, achieve favorable landowner negotiations, and survive development positioning (clear title, zoning compliance, entitlement burden, and the like).*

RECOMMENDATIONS SUMMARY

1. Review SSI Sites Ranked 4+
2. Confirm Infrastructure
3. Complete SSI Phase I Site Readiness Questionnaire
4. Apply Industry Targets
5. Review Existing Sites
6. Nominate SSI Sites for Advancement

RECOMMENDATION NO. 1

1 Review SSI Sites Ranked 4+

ACTION

Review all SSI Phase I sites that achieved a rank of 4 or higher during the Local Site Review Workshop. Prioritize all sites ranked 4 or higher in order of priority for site advancement consideration. Sites currently zoned for the intended project use intensity (for example heavy industrial or commercial) should be strongly considered as primary and backup sites for advancement. Strong consideration should be given to alignment of community industry targets with the site's intended project use.

INTENDED OUTCOME

Create an initial list of candidate sites to nominate for advancement to market, in order of priority.

RATIONALE

Gain perspective on the relative value of all SSI Phase I sites ranked 4 or higher within the context of local industry targets, current economic development real estate assets on the market, and competing sites in neighboring counties, in order to select the best site for market advancement. Establish focus for single-site advancement, with backup sites identified should the priority site warrant suspension due to a material defect, a stall, or an impasse during landowner engagement.

POTENTIAL IMPEDIMENTS

1) Internal disagreement or political bias resulting in a prolonged decision on primary site selection; 2) since the Local Site Review Workshop, the site is now permitted or under construction with competing development; and 3) the landowner has listed the site on the real estate market at a price too far above competitive market values.

1ST

Before listing a new industrial site on the open real estate market, the subject site should be as development-ready as feasible. Adequate transportation access and the ability to readily serve potable water, sewer, natural gas, electricity, and telecommunications and broadband utility services to the subject site is one of the single most important site competitiveness factors. Transportation and utility infrastructure access and capacities must be confirmed.

> ***PRO TIP***
>
> *Proximity of utility infrastructure to the subject site is not the ultimate determination. Service capacity for each utility should be quantified even though customer use specifications are not yet known.*

RECOMMENDATIONS SUMMARY

1. Review SSI Sites Ranked 4+
2. Confirm Infrastructure
3. Complete SSI Phase I Site Readiness Questionnaire
4. Apply Industry Targets
5. Review Existing Sites
6. Nominate SSI Sites for Advancement

RECOMMENDATION NO. 2

2 Confirm Infrastructure

ACTION

Inquire with utility and transportation department personnel to confirm site access and service capacities. Quantify type, available capacities, and performance estimates for potable water, sewer and wastewater, natural gas, electricity, and telecommunications and high-speed internet. Provide infrastructure location maps and line size information. Indicate roadway type and weight limits. Include planned transportation and utility asset expansions and improvements.

INTENDED OUTCOME

Ensure adequate transportation and utility access and service capacities exist for the intended land use intensity (project type) for the subject site. Communicate future infrastructure improvements. Update site maps with specific transportation and utility infrastructure locations and service and performance specifications.

RATIONALE

Adequate transportation access and the ability to readily serve potable water, sewer, natural gas, electricity, and telecommunications and broadband utility services to the subject site is one of the single most important site competitiveness factors. Transportation and utility infrastructure access and capacities must be confirmed.

POTENTIAL IMPEDIMENTS

1) Lack of detailed utility maps and line size and type data; 2) unknown current utility capacity demand and unreliable available-capacity determination; and 3) overly optimistic or unrealistic statements of transportation and utility infrastructure expansion and improvements.

ACTION ITEM

Candidate Site Nomination

1ST

Site data collection serves multiple site advancement functions, including nomination decision support, preliminary due diligence, and marketing and RFI material production. Data is the basis for every site selection effort. Unfortunately, many quality sites do not make the cut simply for lack of thorough and accurate data.

> ***PRO TIP***
>
> *Spend the time to get in the weeds on every facet of the site and its surroundings. A thoroughly and accurately answered SSI Phase I Site Readiness Questionnaire becomes a powerful RFI response tool.*

RECOMMENDATIONS SUMMARY

1. Review SSI Sites Ranked 4+
2. Confirm Infrastructure
3. Complete SSI Phase I Site Readiness Questionnaire
4. Apply Industry Targets
5. Review Existing Sites
6. Nominate SSI Sites for Advancement

RECOMMENDATION NO. 3

3 Complete SSI Phase I Site Readiness Questionnaire

ACTION

Research and compile important site metrics, including information on the physical features and conditions of the subject site as well as community setting, connectivity to transportation and utility assets, planning and zoning requirements, and other data points that support the competitive claims of the site. Use the SSI Phase I Site Readiness Questionnaire to ensure all pertinent site information is collected, verified, and reported.

INTENDED OUTCOME

A thorough understanding of basic site conditions, setting, and general advantages and challenges through data research and compilation. A single document reporting all pertinent site information, consulted for site advancement decision support and future RFI responses.

RATIONALE

Site data compilation is often thin. An organized questionnaire that communicates a wide array of important site data points provides awareness for research and a guide for more detailed reporting.

POTENTIAL IMPEDIMENTS

1) Access to certain information; 2) ability to verify information obtained; and 3) motivation to exhaustively research the information requested and report findings in detail.

1ST

A major consideration in selecting new sites for advancement to market is alignment with industry targets. Primary industry targets should drive candidate site nomination to ensure maximum ability not only to attract but to land desired projects.

> ***PRO TIP***
>
> *Each community's targeted industries should be periodically recalibrated against a number of validation factors, including available quality sites that align with applicable land use intensities, ability to serve the appropriate workforce, regional competition, and current and forecasted industry sector activity. SSI site advancement to market should reflect current, viable industry targets.*

RECOMMENDATIONS SUMMARY

1. Review SSI Sites Ranked 4+
2. Confirm Infrastructure
3. Complete SSI Phase I Site Readiness Questionnaire
4. Apply Industry Targets
5. Review Existing Sites
6. Nominate SSI Sites for Advancement

RECOMMENDATION NO. 4

4 Apply Industry Targets

ACTION

Review current targeted industries and existing industrial and commercial real estate assets. Determine site-to-target alignment of sites currently on the market, considering only quality, competitive sites. Use the findings to guide selection of new or alternative sites for advancement to market that align with primary targeted industry sectors.

INTENDED OUTCOME

Alignment of selected SSI sites for advancement to the real estate market with viable industry targets.

RATIONALE

Communities often have a mismatch between desired industry targets and their industrial and commercial real estate assets. Industry sector site requirements vary widely. While quality sites share many common factors, sector-specific site needs can include total and buildable acreage, boundary configuration, surrounding land use compatibility, utility capacities, and transportation assets. Thoughtfully aligning strategic sites with viable industry targets ensures maximum ability not only to attract but to land desired projects.

POTENTIAL IMPEDIMENTS

1) Viable industry targets have not been identified for the community; 2) pursuit of unrealistic industry targets; and 3) failure to recognize site quality deficiencies in current real estate assets.

1ST

Not all greenfield sites currently listed on the open real estate market are of sufficient size, configuration, or quality to compete for good job-producing projects. However, when sites of verifiable quality are currently available for sale or lease, SSI sites should not compete with existing sites that already serve the intended industry targets.

> ***PRO TIP***
>
> *SSI sites can be used as a quality benchmark for an apolitical, objective comparison to sites currently on the real estate market. If the sites currently on the market fall short of a nationally competitive quality standard, SSI sites should be advanced to market.*

RECOMMENDATIONS SUMMARY

1. Review SSI Sites Ranked 4+
2. Confirm Infrastructure
3. Complete SSI Phase I Site Readiness Questionnaire
4. Apply Industry Targets
5. Review Existing Sites
6. Nominate SSI Sites for Advancement

STRONGLY CONSIDER CONSULTING ASSISTANCE

RECOMMENDATION NO. 5

5 Review Existing Sites

ACTION

Review the inventory of all existing industrial and commercial greenfield sites marketed as economic development real estate assets. Perform a general site quality assessment relative to the SSI Phase I sites. Where competitive existing sites are verified, determine their suitability to support viable industry targets. Use the findings to guide nomination of SSI Phase I sites for advancement to the real estate market.

INTENDED OUTCOME

A qualitative understanding of overall site quality for the existing industrial and commercial real estate assets currently on the market, and decision support for nominating SSI Phase I sites that do not compete with existing competitive sites.

RATIONALE

SSI Program sites should not compete with existing properties on the market that are of sufficient quality and suitability to attract and land targeted industry projects. SSI Phase I sites should be selected for advancement to market in consideration of existing industrial and commercial real estate assets.

POTENTIAL IMPEDIMENTS

1) Failure to recognize site quality deficiencies in current real estate assets; 2) insufficient property and site information to assess general site quality; and 3) not all sites available for sale or lease are published on the open real estate market.

1ST

Informed by a detail-oriented and measured process, candidate site nomination can now be made with confidence. The right SSI Phase I sites will begin advancement to the real estate market: sites that support viable industry targets, have a high likelihood of surviving site due diligence, and will not compete with competitive existing properties.

PRO TIP

SSI Phase I sites nominated for advancement to market still have a long way to go to active listing, and there are several fail points along the way. Nominating multiple candidate sites, prioritized for advancement focus, gives the best chance of graduating an SSI Phase I site to the real estate market. Selecting backup sites is a must.

RECOMMENDATIONS SUMMARY

1. Review SSI Sites Ranked 4+
2. Confirm Infrastructure
3. Complete SSI Phase I Site Readiness Questionnaire
4. Apply Industry Targets
5. Review Existing Sites
6. Nominate SSI Sites for Advancement

STRONGLY CONSIDER CONSULTING ASSISTANCE

RECOMMENDATION NO. 6

6 Nominate SSI Sites for Advancement

ACTION

Select primary and secondary SSI Phase I sites as candidates for advancement to market. Use the findings from the previously completed action items as site nomination decision support. Nominate primary and secondary sites with the highest and best economic development value to the community.

INTENDED OUTCOME

Nomination of a primary site and a minimum of two backup sites, assigned priority as candidate sites for advancement to the open real estate market. The site is ready for the next primary action item: Landowner Engagement.

RATIONALE

SSI Phase I sites nominated for advancement to market still have a long way to go to a formal listing. Many sites will be immediately eliminated by landowners unwilling to sell. The landowner engagement process can be long and arduous and can end in impasse over land price or terms. A working list of candidate sites, prioritized by local economic development value, ensures advancement focus and the best chance of graduating to the open real estate market.

POTENTIAL IMPEDIMENTS

1) Internal disagreement or political bias resulting in a prolonged decision on primary site selection; 2) since the Local Site Review Workshop, the site is now permitted or under construction with competing development; and 3) the landowner has listed the site on the real estate market at a price too far above competitive market values.

Landowner Engagement

Landowner Engagement is the second site advancement action item toward graduating an SSI Program site to the open real estate market. While contacting property owners is very much a local function, SSI Phase III provides best practices, strategy development, and proven tactics for stimulating landowner interest. There is only one opportunity to make a good first impression. Successful landowner engagement requires doing your homework, having a customized communications strategy, and tools for effective negotiation.

The ten recommendations for Landowner Engagement are listed at right in sequence. Their detailed action, intended outcome, rationale, and potential impediments, together with the recommendations for Development Positioning and Site Programming, are delivered with a funded Phase III engagement and applied to the first cohort of nominated sites.

> **Development Positioning** (third action item): property rezoning, permitting assessment, site pre-engineering, and securing entitlements. **Site Programming** (fourth action item, also called marketing resource production): a site data package that exceeds the minimum publishing requirements, a Site Profile and conceptual site plan, and publication to the state sites and buildings database.

PURPOSE

EDO guidance for navigating the landowner engagement process and securing control of the subject site at a successfully negotiated fair market value price.

OBJECTIVES

Stimulate landowner interest in placing property in the SSI Program through education, outreach, and relationship building. Conduct a site visit to confirm site condition and suitability for development. Negotiate a fair market value sale or lease price. Secure a real estate purchase option agreement.

SECOND ACTION ITEM: RECOMMENDATIONS SUMMARY

1. Conduct Anonymous Property Research
2. Develop Communication Strategy
3. Initiate Landowner Contact
4. Conduct Limited Property Appraisal
5. Conduct Site Visit
6. Obtain Letter of Intent
7. Perform Title Research
8. Negotiate Land Price
9. Secure Real Estate Purchase Option Agreement
10. Enter Site in the State Sites and Buildings Database

Contact and edition record

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LOCATION Design Group

SSI PROGRAM

EDITION RECORD

Draft V1, March 2024. Prepared by Leotta Location and Design (LL+D) for the Indiana Economic Development Corporation under the SSI Program professional services agreement; delivered as draft guidance. Not finalized when the program paused in 2025.

Clean edition, November 2026. Prepared by Location Design Group, LLC. Corrections to the draft: template placeholders replaced with Indiana references; typographical errors corrected throughout; Phase I figures reconciled to the program record (1,811 sites, average 194 acres, all 92 counties); the fourth action item named consistently as Site Programming; publication target named as the state sites and buildings database. Recommendations, their sequence, and their substance are unchanged from the draft.

Scope. Action Item 1 in full (six recommendations); Action Item 2 in summary (ten recommendations); Action Items 3 and 4 outlined. Detailed guidance for Action Items 2 through 4 is delivered with a funded Phase III engagement.

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